

THE LOST CAFE'S

Written by JSM

PG - 1

FADE IN:

EXT. CITY STREET - CHAI KI TAPRI - EARLY MORNING - REALITY A

Steam curls in the chill air. RAJU CHACHA (60s, kind-eyed, salt-and-pepper beard) pours tea for a small crowd.

ARJUN (early 30s, handsome in a pensive way, eyes carrying old wounds) stands silently at the corner, watching commuters rush past.

Raju Chacha hands him a glass of chai before he asks.

RAJU CHACHA

Ek cutting, kam meetha -- jaante hi hoon!

ARJUN

(soft smile)

Yehi toh Khas baat hai yaah ki, Chacha.

Arjun leans against the stall, sipping his tea. Across the street: THE LOST CAFE glows in the morning light, its windows misted, the tables inside empty except for UNCLE RAVI (60s, bustling, a silent observer).

Arjun's gaze lingers on the cafe, as always.

Raju Chacha wipes his hands, glancing at Arjun's familiar routine.

RAJU CHACHA

(beta, paanch saal se roz yahin, hai na?)

Five years you come, every morning. But why all these years just watching that cafe?

ARJUN

(covering pain with a laugh)

Bas aise hi, lagta hai fancy hai. Coffee ka budget nahi hai.

RAJU CHACHA

(teasing)

Arey, ek din chal hi jao andar. Kabhi treat toh karo apne aap ko.

ARJUN

(hollow)

Kuch jagah bas dekhne ke liye hoti hain, Chacha.

Arjun finishes his chai, nods goodbye.

ARJUN (CONT'D)

Kal milte hain.

RAJU CHACHA

(smiling, still puzzled)

Haan, roz ki tarah.

Arjun walks away, his eyes flicker once more at the cafe he can't enter.

CUT TO:

PG - 2

EXT. CITY STREET - CORPORATE OFFICE BUILDING - MORNING - REALITY A

Arjun walks briskly, briefcase in hand, blending into the flow of suited professionals. His face is composed, almost serene, but his eyes are distant.

INT. OFFICE FLOOR - DAY

Open-plan office, bustling yet sterile. Arjun sits at his desk, multiple screens displaying advertising campaigns. He types methodically, focused but mechanically.

SAMEER (30s, jovial, empathetic) approaches holding a briefcase and pulls up a chair beside Arjun.

SAMEER

(smiling)

Aur Bhai aate hi kaam shuru kar diya?

ARJUN

(glancing up, natural but forced smile/mild-laugh)

Haan Sammy, Bas roje ki aadat, bina kaam ke waqt ka paisa nahi milega na.

Isiliye busy rehna padta hai kaam me.

SAMEER

(taking his chair sitting beside Arjun)

tere jaisa banda dhoondhne se bhi nahi milega isse company ko.

Ek terko hi maine dekha itne saalon me, jisne apne kaam ko itna sambhalke kiya ho.

Arjun nods modestly, but his eyes betray a hidden ache.

SAMEER (CONT'D)

Chal ab presentation bana lete hai nai to boss aake khursi or job dono khichlega

Sameer pats Arjun's shoulder and starts working on his desk.

Arjun exhales slowly, returning to his screens.

CUT TO:

PG - 3

INT. ARJUN'S APARTMENT - REALITY A - EVENING

A modest one-bedroom apartment. Clean but soulless. Everything in its place, nothing out of order.

Arjun enters, loosening his tie. He sets his briefcase down with practiced precision – same spot, every day.

The apartment is silent. No music, no voices, no life.

KITCHEN CORNER

Arjun opens the refrigerator. Minimal contents: bottled water, takeout containers, a single apple.

He pulls out a container of leftover food, microwaves it without looking.

LIVING AREA

He sits on the couch, eating mechanically while scrolling through his phone. Work emails. More work emails.

The TV is off. The silence is oppressive.

His eyes drift to the window – the city lights outside, couples walking together on the street below.

He looks away quickly.

BEDROOM - LATER

Arjun brushes his teeth, staring at himself in the bathroom mirror. For a moment, something flickers in his eyes – a question, a memory, a longing.

He shakes it off, rinses his mouth.

He changes into sleep clothes, the routine automatic.

The bed is made perfectly – only one side ever slept in. The other side pristine, untouched.

Arjun lies down, staring at the ceiling.

His phone buzzes. A work notification. He ignores it.

He closes his eyes.

The silence wraps around him like a shroud.

FADE TO BLACK.

ARJUN (V.O.)
(barely a whisper)
Five years...

CUT TO:

PG - 4

DREAM SEQUENCE - INT. THE LOST CAFE - NIGHT

Soft, golden light. Everything slightly ethereal, dreamlike. Colors are more saturated than reality.

ARJUN sits at a table by the window. But he's different here – relaxed, genuinely smiling, alive.

Across from him sits a WOMAN (late 20s, we see her only in soft focus, her face not quite clear). Her laughter fills the space like music.

WOMAN

(warmth in her voice)

You always get that look when you're planning something.

ARJUN

(grinning, in love)

What look?

WOMAN

That mischievous one. Like you're about to surprise me.

ARJUN

Maybe I am.

He reaches across the table, takes her hand. The gesture is so natural, so familiar – five years of intimacy in one touch.

UNCLE RAVI (in the dream, younger, smiling) brings them coffee. Two cups. Their cups.

UNCLE RAVI

Your usual table is always waiting.

The woman squeezes Arjun's hand.

WOMAN

Should we tell them our news?

ARJUN

(hesitant but happy)

Let's wait. I want to enjoy this moment.

She leans forward, her face coming slightly into focus – beautiful, radiant, HOME.

WOMAN

I love you.

ARJUN

(completely certain)

Always.

The cafe glows with impossible warmth. This is happiness. This is belonging. This is everything.

SUDDENLY – the Alarm SOUNDS.

END DREAM SEQUENCE

INT. ARJUN'S BEDROOM - REALITY A - EARLY MORNING

Arjun's eyes SNAP OPEN. He's breathing heavily, disoriented.

He sits up in bed, hand to his chest. The apartment is moon-lit and silent.

ARJUN

(whispered, confused)

What... what was that?

He looks around his empty bedroom. The other side of the bed – untouched.

He runs his hand over his face, trying to shake off the dream.

But the feeling lingers. The warmth. The happiness. Her.

ARJUN (CONT'D)

(to himself, disturbed)

Why now? After all this time...

He picks up his phone from the nightstand. 3:17 AM.

He stares at the ceiling, unable to go back to sleep.

The dream felt too real. Too vivid. Too... right.

FADE TO:

PG - 5

SECTION 1: PEAKING JEALOUSY + THE CAUSE

DREAM SEQUENCE (SEEMINGLY) - INT. THE LOST CAFE - DAY

Golden, ethereal light. Dreamlike quality persists.

MEERA (late 20s, radiant, FULL FACE REVEAL - clear, beautiful, warm)
sits alone at window table. Two coffee cups.

She pulls out phone, scrolls to: "TC 

Presses call.

INTERCUT: PHONE CONVERSATION

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - DAY (DREAMLIKE)

We see only TC's BACK. Sharp suit, expensive watch visible as he
reaches for buzzing phone.

Screen shows: "Meera 

His hand trembles. He answers.

TC (V.O.)
(warm, hiding everything)
Meera! Kya baat hai?

MEERA

TC, I need advice on something really important.

EXT. OUTSIDE OFFICE BUILDING - CONTINUOUS

A FLOCK OF PIGEONS on the ledge. Peaceful. Cooing. Roosting casually.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

TC (V.O.)

Haan bol. I'm always here for you.

MEERA

It's about Arjun and me. We've been
together five years now...

His back tenses. Hand grips desk edge, knuckles white.

EXT. OUTSIDE OFFICE BUILDING - CONTINUOUS

The pigeons sense something. Growing restless. Shifting.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

MEERA

(taking breath)

I'm thinking of talking to him about...
marriage.

THE EXACT MOMENT SHE SAYS "MARRIAGE" -

EXT. OUTSIDE OFFICE BUILDING - CONTINUOUS

ALL THE PIGEONS EXPLODE INTO FLIGHT.

A VIOLENT ERUPTION of wings. Dozens scatter in all directions.
Chaotic. Urgent. Fleeing as if sensing catastrophe.

Not one remains.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

SILENCE. TC's back goes rigid. A long, painful beat.

The empty ledge visible through window behind him.

TC (V.O.)
(forcing it out - perfect doglapan)
Marriage? Meera, that's... amazing.
You both are perfect together.

INT. THE LOST CAFE - CONTINUOUS

MEERA
(relieved, grateful)
Really? You think so? TC, you're my
oldest friend. Your opinion matters so much.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

TC (V.O.)
(each word agony)
He's lucky. Bahut lucky. You should
definitely talk to him.

MEERA (V.O.)
Thanks, TC. You're the best friend ever.
I knew I could count on you.

TC (V.O.)
(hollow)
Haan... always.

MEERA (V.O.)
Okay, I'll let you get back to work.
Thank you so much!

She hangs up.

TC sits frozen, phone still to ear. Dial tone drones.

Then - he lowers phone slowly. Still only BACK visible.

ONE MINUTE WAIT - ANXIOUS MOVEMENT

TC doesn't move for five seconds. Then –

His shoulders SHAKE. Once. Twice.

He stands abruptly. Paces to the window. Still BACK TO CAMERA.

Stares at the empty ledge where pigeons were.

His hand forms a fist. Releases. Forms again.

He turns, paces back to desk. Sits. Stands again.

Restless. Agitated. Jealousy eating him alive.

He grabs his phone. Puts it down. Grabs it again.

Unlocks it. Screen glow on his unseen face.

Opens contacts. Scrolls.

We see (over shoulder): "बाबा"

His thumb hovers. Still BACK TO US.

Internal war. Desperation vs. pride. Desperation vs. consequence.

Ten seconds of hovering.

Then –

He presses CALL.

INTERCUT: TANTRIK PHONE CONVERSATION

INT. TANTRIK BABA'S SPACE - NIGHT (SHADOWS, CANDLES)

Gnarled HAND picks up old rotary phone. Only shadows visible.

Flickering candles. Smoke curling.

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)
(ancient, knowing)
Kaun?

TC (V.O.)
(hollow, from back view)
Babaji... Tarun bol raha hoon. Do saal
pehle mere colleague ne refer kiya tha.

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)
Haan, yaad hai. Kya chahiye, beta?

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

TC's back rigid. Hand gripping phone.

TC (V.O.)
(desperate)
Kaam karna hai. Bahut zaroori kaam.

INT. TANTRIK BABA'S SPACE - CONTINUOUS

Candles FLICKER violently. Smoke thickens.

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)
(amused, dark)
Kaisa kaam?

TC (V.O.)
Abhi details nahi de sakta. Par... urgent hai.

Long, heavy pause. Shadows deepen.

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)
Nischintra raho beta. Sab chizo ki
vyavastha sambhav hai.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

TC's shoulders sag with relief.

TC (V.O.)

Sach mein, Babaji?

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)

Haan. Par yaad rakhna - tantra apna kaam
karega. Lekin kaise? Main nahi bata sakta.
Niyati ko seedha mod nahi sakte. Bas...
ghatna hogi.

TC (V.O.)

(doesn't care)

Kuch bhi ho, Babaji. Bas...

TANTRIK BABA (V.O.)

(final, ominous)

Tumhare dan ko fal zarur lagega.

Line goes DEAD.

INT. TANTRIK BABA'S SPACE - CONTINUOUS

CLOSE ON: The candle FLARES bright, then goes completely DARK.

INT. CORPORATE OFFICE - TC'S DESK - CONTINUOUS

TC sits motionless. Still only BACK visible. Phone in hand.

The curse has been CAST.

The dreamlike golden quality DARKENS to oppressive nightmare.

SECTION 2: UNKNOWN VICTIM

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD (appears in darkness): "REALITY A"

The dreamlike quality SHATTERS.

INT. INDUSTRIAL GYM - EARLY MORNING - REALITY A (HARSH, REAL)

CLANG of metal. Chalk dust. Concrete and iron.

ARJUN loads a barbell. Heavy plates. He's in the zone - wrist wraps, lifting belt, grim focus.

This is the gym-freak version. Rough. Intense. Using pain as armor.

He chalks his hands, grips the bar, PULLS. Deadlift. Clean. Controlled fury.

Another rep. Veins cord. Breath harsh.

He sets the bar down, stares at his reflection in the mirror.

For a SPLIT SECOND - the mirror wavers. A flicker of golden light. The cafe. Her smile.

He blinks. Gone.

SPOTTER (V.O.)

Bro, focus kidhar hai aaj?

ARJUN

(shaking it off)

Kuch nahi. Ek set aur.

He grips the bar again. Unaware. Completely unaware that across realities, something has been set in motion.

Something that will change everything.

The weights feel heavier today. He doesn't know why.

PG - 6

SECTION 1: THE OFFICE - CONFUSED STATE

INT. OFFICE FLOOR - REALITY A - DAY

Arjun sits at his desk, staring blankly at his computer screen. The cursor blinks. He hasn't typed anything in minutes.

His hand rests on the mouse, motionless.

CLOSE ON: His eyes - distant, unfocused. Somewhere else entirely.

FLASH - DREAM FRAGMENT:

Golden light. The cafe. Her laugh. Her hand in his.

BACK TO PRESENT:

Arjun blinks hard, snaps back. Rubs his face roughly.

SAMEER (O.S.)

Arjun?

Arjun startles slightly, turns.

SAMEER

(concerned, standing at his desk)

Bro, third time I'm calling you. Kahan

kho gaya? Presentation review hai 10 minutes mein.

ARJUN

(forcing focus)

Haan... haan, sorry. Bas... neend achhi nahi aayi kal raat.

SAMEER

(studying him)

Tu theek hai na? Aaj subah se kaafi off lag raha hai. Something going on?

ARJUN

(quick denial)

Nahi nahi, sab theek hai. Just tired.

SAMEER

(not convinced but letting it go)

Okay. Par agar kuch hai toh bata.

Coffee leke aata hoon.

Sameer walks away. Arjun exhales slowly.

He turns back to his screen. Tries to focus.

But his eyes drift to the window - the city outside.

ARJUN (V.O.)

(internal, barely whispered)

Why now? After five years... why now?

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - REALITY A - LATER

Arjun sits with colleagues around a table. A PRESENTATION plays on screen - campaign visuals, brand messaging.

BOSS (40s, sharp)

...so the target demographic responds to emotional authenticity. Arjun,

your thoughts on the messaging tone?

Silence.

BOSS (CONT'D)

Arjun?

Everyone looks at him. He's staring at the presentation but not seeing it.

On screen: A couple holding hands. Happy. In love.

His jaw clenches.

SAMEER

(quietly, nudging him)

Boss ne question pucha.

Arjun snaps back. Caught.

ARJUN

(scrambling)

Sorry, I... could you repeat that?

BOSS

(irritated)

The messaging tone. Your input?

ARJUN

(forcing professional mode)

Right. Yes. Emotional authenticity works, but we need to balance aspiration with relatability. Too perfect feels false.

BOSS

(satisfied)

Good. Let's refine that angle.

The meeting continues. But Arjun's eyes keep drifting back to that image - the happy couple.

SECTION 2: THE CURSE MANIFESTS

INT. ARJUN'S APARTMENT - REALITY A - NIGHT (7:00 PM)

TITLE CARD: 7:00 PM

The apartment is quiet. Organized. Punctual routine.

Arjun enters, sets his gym bag and briefcase down. Same spot. Every day. Precision.

INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

He opens the fridge. Pulls out meal-prep container (chicken, rice, vegetables). Microwaves it.

While waiting, he checks his phone. Work emails. Nothing personal.

The microwave BEEPS. He eats at the kitchen counter, standing. Mechanical. Fast. Efficient.

Finishes. Washes the container. Places it in the drying rack.

Checks his watch: 7:23 PM.

INT. BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

Brushes teeth. Washes face. The routine is armor.

He looks at himself in the mirror. For a moment, something flickers in his eyes - exhaustion, confusion, longing.

He shakes it off. Looks away.

INT. BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

Changes into sleep clothes. Sets phone on nightstand.

Checks the time: 7:47 PM.

He lies down. Stares at ceiling.

Closes his eyes.

Tries to sleep.

The silence is oppressive.

His breathing slows. Sleep beginning to take him.

Then-

A FLICKER. The room dims. The atmosphere SHIFTS.

THE CURSE/GLITCH ACTIVATES

The air becomes heavier. Dreamlike quality seeps in.

His eyes are closed, but something is happening.

DREAM SEQUENCE - THE MARRIAGE PROPOSAL

The golden, ethereal light returns. Stronger now. More vivid.

INT. THE LOST CAFE - EVENING (DREAMLIKE/REALITY B)

MEERA and ARJUN (Reality B version - fitness guy, relaxed, happy) sit at their usual table by the window.

The cafe glows with warmth. UNCLE RAVI moves in the background, smiling at them.

But there's tension in the air. A nervous energy.

MEERA looks beautiful but anxious. She's been building courage for this moment.

ARJUN (Reality B) seems content but slightly distracted, unaware of what's coming.

MEERA

(taking a breath)

Arjun, there's something I want to talk about.

ARJUN (Reality B)

(turning to her, attentive)

Haan? Kya baat hai?

She reaches across the table, takes his hand.

MEERA

We've been coming to this cafe for five years now.
This table... it's ours, you know?

ARJUN (Reality B)

(smiling, genuine)

Best part of my week. Always has been.

MEERA

(gathering courage)

Five years together, Arjun. Five years of...
this. Of us.

She looks into his eyes. He senses something big is coming.

MEERA (CONT'D)

I think... I think we're ready for the next step.

A beat. His expression shifts - something flickers. Hesitation?

MEERA (CONT'D)

(voice trembling slightly with hope and fear)

What do you think about... marriage?

The word hangs in the air.

SILENCE.

ARJUN (Reality B) doesn't answer immediately. His face -
conflicted. Not the instant "yes" she hoped for.

ARJUN (Reality B)

(carefully)

Marriage? That's... Meera, that's a big step.

MEERA

(reading his hesitation, trying to hide hurt)

I know. But... we've been together five years.
Don't you think...?

ARJUN (Reality B)

(struggling)

I do. I mean, yes, it's been amazing. You're amazing. It's just... the timing...

The golden light FLICKERS. Darkens slightly.

MEERA

(forcing a smile, but wounded)

Timing? Or... something else?

ARJUN (Reality B)

No, it's not- I just need to think about it.

Can we... can we talk about this more?

The moment fractures. The proposal hangs unanswered.

MEERA nods, but her eyes show pain. Disappointment.

The golden light WAVERS, becoming unstable.

INT. ARJUN'S BEDROOM - REALITY A - NIGHT

ARJUN (Reality A) JOLTS AWAKE.

Breathing hard. Disoriented. Sweating.

He sits up in bed, hand to chest.

ARJUN

(whispered, shaken)

What... what the hell was that?

He looks around his dark bedroom. The other side of the bed - empty, as always.

But this dream was DIFFERENT. More vivid. More REAL.

He saw her face clearly this time. MEERA. Her name echoes in his mind though he doesn't consciously know it.

And that moment - her asking about marriage. His hesitation.

Why did HE hesitate in the dream? Why did it feel like HE was disappointing her?

ARJUN (CONT'D)

(to the darkness, confused and scared)

This isn't just a dream. This feels... real.

He picks up his phone. 11:34 PM.

He's only been asleep for three hours, but it felt like a lifetime in that cafe.

He lies back down, but his eyes stay open.

Staring at the ceiling. Mind racing.

The curse is working. The glitch is growing stronger.

And he has no idea what's happening to him.

FADE TO BLACK.

END PAGE 6

CUT TO:

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PAGE 7

SECTION 2.1 (SHORT): GLITCH EFFECT-THE FIRST CRACK

INT. THE LOST CAFE – EVENING – REALITY B

Meera's "marriage" question lingers. The golden light in the cafe flickers-Arjun B freezes, a shiver runs through him. For a split second, he's lost in a haze; the sound of clinking cups grow distant, the world seems to pulse.

He snaps back, tries to recover composure.

MEERA

(tentative, uncertain)

Arjun?

ARJUN B

(soft, distracted)

Sorry-just felt... off for a second.

He blinks, managing a wry smile, but it's clear to us something inside him has just *changed*-though he's trying hard to hide it.

We HOLD on this moment-small, but full of foreboding.

SECTION 2.2 (LONG): THE EVERYDAY SUCCESSFUL MAN-REALITY B

INT. BEDROOM – MORNING

Sunlight pours in through half-open curtains. Arjun B wakes beside Meera; she murmurs something sleepily, and both share a relaxed, loving glance before rising.

INT. KITCHEN

Both make breakfast together in practiced rhythm. Smoothies, protein, a touch of playful competition ("Who's faster today?"). Meera reads headlines on her tablet; Arjun B preps coffee, pours it just as she likes.

MEERA

Today: Uncle Ravi, 6PM?

ARJUN B

(always a smile)

Table's already reserved. Ritual hai hamara.

INT. HOME GYM SPACE

Arjun B does a focused, efficient workout: stretches, perfect-form pushups, planks, some light weights. He checks his smartwatch, looks satisfied. Meera appears in frame, playfully tosses him a towel.

MEERA

Show-off.

They both laugh.

INT. OFFICE – DAY

Arjun B in conference room, leading a pitch. Engaged, respected, a leader who listens. His team includes a broad mix of people; he compliments a junior's fresh idea, making her beam.

LATER, HIS CUBICLE

A text flashes on his phone:

UNCLE RAVI: "Beta, reservation pakka. See you both!"

He replies: "Wouldn't miss it."

INT. EVENING CITY STREET

Arjun B and Meera walk from office to the cafe, easy arms-around-waists, making space for each other on the crowded sidewalk.

ARJUN B

(remembers and stops at a flower vendor, buys a single lily)
For you—just because.

Meera grins, blushes. They continue, harmony embodied.

INT. THE LOST CAFE – EVENING

Uncle Ravi greets them by name. They're given "their" table by the window. A string of tiny rituals: Arjun B orders her favorite pastry; she teases him about sticking to his "plan" but still takes a bite.

They laugh, talk, sometimes just sit and watch the evening crowd. Couples, families, students. Warmth, belonging, a sense of "home."

UNCLE RAVI

(whispering conspiratorially as he pours coffee)
You two—never miss a week. Makes this place special for me too, beta.

ARJUN B

(smiling, genuineness)
Yahi toh hai apna second home, Uncle.

Meera catches Arjun's gaze: her eyes are full of hope.

We HOLD on this image—the life that looks "perfect."
Underneath, a barely-there ripple of discord, almost invisible.
But we—the audience—know: the glitch is coming for this world.

FADE TO BLACK.

END PAGE 7

CUT TO:

PG - 8

EXT. HOTEL BANQUET HALL – NIGHT

A luxury car pulls up. Flashbulbs. VALETS open doors.

Arjun B, in a tailored suit, steps out. Meera beside him in a graceful saree, both radiant. They move down a red carpet, hand in hand, Meera's eyes beaming pride.

INT. BANQUET HALL – NIGHT

Awards ceremony. Tables full of Mumbai's ad industry elite. Banners read: "Agency of the Year - Rising Stars."

Arjun's face slides across a giant video screen as highlights play—happy office, ad campaigns, social initiatives.

The emcee calls out:

EMCEE (O.S.)

And the 'Creative Leader of the Year' goes to... Arjun Bhatt!

Applause. Meera cheers, dabbing a tear. Arjun B rises, hugs her, walks to stage, hand on heart in humility.

Among the crowd: TARUN (TC), isolated at an unremarkable table. He wears a tight smile, shadowed eyes fixed on Arjun.

Arjun B gives a simple, grateful speech—thanks his team, his partner.

ARJUN B (FROM STAGE)

And to Meera... you're my true inspiration and home.

EMCEE (O.S.)

Let's hear it, folks!

Thunderous applause. Meera stands, meets Tarun's gaze across the crowd, her face glowing with pride.

AT THE PARTY – LATER

Cocktails, congratulations. People clamor for selfies with Arjun B, sharing stories of campaigns and creative wins.

Meera finds herself beside TC.

MEERA

(smiling, genuine)

I still can't believe how far he's come, Tarun! Five years ago, he was an unknown. Now... look at him. Sometimes I wonder if he ever takes it in.

TARUN

(fake enthusiasm, doglapan underneath)

Haan, haan, dekha toh sab ne. Arjun Bhatt, the golden boy. Sab kuch mil gaya usse na-Naam, paisa, trophy... aur tum.

He raises his glass, but his tone is hollow, eyes cold.

MEERA

(defends gently)

He deserves it, Tarun. Nobody works harder. But I know—sabse zyada khush woh mere saath hi hai. Baakiyon ka kya hi hai.

TARUN

(toasts, sharp smile)

Of course, Meera. For some people, one trophy's enough.

Meera looks at him, uncertainty flickering.

IN THE CROWD

Arjun B catches this exchange. He watches as Tarun melts away into the guests, blending out, unsatisfied.

Arjun joins Meera, pulling her close.

ARJUN B
You okay?

MEERA
(smiling, honest)
Now I am.

They share a quiet look—one of earned solidity and love.

INT. APARTMENT – BEDROOM – NIGHT

Arjun B and Meera, in bed, wrapping up the night.

MEERA
Today was big, na?

ARJUN B
(smiling at her, sincere)
Big only because you were with me.

She settles next to him, content. The city glories outside are distant; their world is here, small and warm.

ARJUN B (CONT'D)
(soft, meaning it)
All this—(gestures at trophy on shelf)—means nothing without you.

Meera kisses his hand, eyes shining.

MEERA
Love you.

ARJUN B

I love you more.

They fall into quiet, the award glimmering in the background, but the focus firmly on their entwined hands.

FADE TO BLACK.

END PAGE 8

CUT TO:

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SECTION 1: NIGHTMARE GLITCH (DREAM CONNECTION – ARJUN B IN ARJUN A's LIFE)

INT. ARJUN B & MEERA'S APARTMENT – NIGHT

A peaceful apartment. Arjun B, trophy beside the bed, drifts to sleep next to Meera.

CLOSE ON: Arjun B's face as he enters deep sleep—the golden light turns cold, and the world bends around him.

DREAM/SUBCONSCIOUS–GLITCHED REALITY

MONTAGE:

Arjun B (now experiencing Arjun A's world, as Arjun A):

- Wakes up in a dim studio apartment, other half of the bed empty, pillow untouched.
- Non-veg breakfast, eggs and tea, eaten alone at a table crowded by protein tubs and lifting gear.
- Gym: rough, chalk-dust air, Arjun A's powerlifting routine—rough, relentless, solitary, pain-as-coping.
- 9-5 job: mechanical office space, polite "good mornings" with hidden emptiness, Sameer's familiar banter ("Aur bhai, kaam ka bhoot utarna bhi zaruri hai kabhi!").
- Street outside: chai ki tapri ritual. Raju Chacha preps the usual, offers a smile. Arjun A, lost in routine, always glances—never enters—the glowing Lost Cafe across the street.
- Back home, prepared meal, food containers lined up for the week.
- Night. The routine ends again: phone checked for missed connections (none), bed empty, lights out at 9:00 PM sharp.

ON ARJUN B (experiencing all of this in desperation):

A sense of loss, confusion, longing—for Meera, for color, for life.

DREAM ENDS.

SECTION 2: ARJUN B AWAKES – DISORIENTATION/FEAR

INT. ARJUN B & MEERA'S APARTMENT – BEDROOM – MORNING (7:00 AM)

Arjun B wakes with a jolt, sweating, gasping for air. The light is bright, but he blinks at the ceiling, dazed—he finds his hand searching the other side of the bed. It's cold. Empty.

A beat of anxiety, panic creeping in. He sits up quickly, scanning the room. "Meera?"—the sound is barely more than a whisper.

A long, unsettling pause.

Then:

The door opens. Meera steps in, smiling warmly, carrying a tray with breakfast and tea.

MEERA

Good morning, love. Made your favorite.

Arjun B's body finally exhales. He covers his face, fighting tears of relief.

ARJUN B

(soft, voice cracking)

Good morning... thank God.

MEERA

(settling beside him)

Nightmares again?

He nods, pulls her into a long, grateful embrace.

She brushes his hair with her hand, soothing the break between worlds.

SECTION 3: ARJUN A (NOW DREAMING OF ARJUN B'S LIFE)

INT. ARJUN A'S APARTMENT – EARLY MORNING

Now Arjun A lies asleep. The dream world *shifts*—he finds himself briefly in a golden, sunlit apartment. A woman's laugh in the kitchen. Green smoothies and yoga mats, gentle routines, trophies that mean nothing compared to love.

He tries to call out—but his voice doesn't form. The happiness feels alien and excruciatingly out of reach.

FLASH—The sound of an alarm. He bolts upright in his own reality (the lonely apartment, protein tubs, no Meera). For a fleeting moment, he can't tell what is real.

He sits up, breathless, as the confusion from both realities collides literally and emotionally.

SECTION 4: THE GLITCH EXPLAINED—WHY ARJUN B FALTERED

INT. ARJUN B & MEERA'S APARTMENT – MORNING

Meera sits at the edge of the bed, sipping tea, watching Arjun B struggle to steady himself.

CUT TO:

FLASHES of the cafe, the moment she proposed.

Arjun B's face flickering between YES and utter speechlessness.

INT. SUBCONSCIOUS SPACE (INTERCUT – VISUAL METAPHOR)

Within the glitch, R. Madhavan-style Arjun A and fit, happy Arjun B face each other across a glass pane.

ARJUN A (V.O.)

(aching, helpless)

I never had the answer—so neither did you.

ON ARJUN B:

Trying desperately to say "yes," his mouth moves but words won't form.

He's stuck, because in some other life, his other self never found the courage to choose love.

BACK IN APARTMENT:

Arjun B just holds Meera tighter. The curse/glitch is now at full strength—their lives, and hearts, out of sync.

FADE OUT.

END PAGE 9

CUT TO:

PG - 10

TITLE OVER: "THE DELAY"

TIME LAPSE – 5 DAYS PASS IN REALITY B

SERIES OF DAY/NIGHT SHOTS

EXT. COUPLE'S APARTMENT – MORNING (DAY 1)

Sunlight through curtains.

Arjun B and Meera in quiet routine. Polite smiles, but a new distance.

INT. KITCHEN – DAY (DAY 2)

Meera pours two coffees. Arjun B, distracted, barely sips his, lost in thought.

She watches, worried but says nothing.

INT. BEDROOM – NIGHT (NIGHT 2)

Both in bed, backs turned. Meera stares at ceiling, Arjun B listens to city noises, awake.

A beat. He closes his eyes, bracing for another nightmare.

DREAM SEQUENCE – NIGHT 2

(Arjun B sees flashes of Reality A:

- Young Arjun A at the cafe with Meera, laughter and warmth.
- Then a sudden, sharp fight; the cafe's light grows cold.
- Arjun A storms out, Meera's tears at the window.
- Time-lapse: Arjun A alone, seasons change, the tapri ritual, the cafe never entered again.
- Arjun B watches—all this isn't just a dream, it's a cautionary replay.)

MORNING (DAY 3)

Meera packs a travel bag.

MEERA

(smiling, gentle)

Going to Lonavala with the girls. Back in three days. I thought maybe... you could use some space, time to think?

Arjun B simply nods. She hugs him. He holds on a second too long.

MEERA (CONT'D)

I'll call, okay?

ARJUN B

(soft)

Thank you, Meera.

He watches her leave—door closing feels a little too final.

INT. APARTMENT – VARIOUS

- Arjun B alone, trying to focus on work, distracted, haunted, scrolling through old photos.

- At night, lying awake. Always, the dreams come:

- Reality A's gym; a cold apartment; meal-prep for one.

- Young Arjun A's face torn between pride and heartbreak.

- The pivotal moment at the cafe:

MEERA (A): "Is this the end?"

ARJUN A: silent, unable to answer. The separation cemented.

INT. APARTMENT – NIGHT (NIGHT 5)

Arjun B sits at the dining table, untouched meal before him. He types and retypes a message on his phone to Meera—never sends it.

He closes his eyes.

INNER V.O. (Arjun B)

What if the worst possibility... is real? What if I'm staring at the shadow of a choice not yet made?

FLASH MONTAGE—DREAMS (Arjun A's journey):

- The breakup in cafe.

- The years of avoidance.

- Seeing the tapri again and again.

- Never going back inside.

BACK TO ARJUN B-APARTMENT, NIGHT

He wakes from the nightmare, sweating, breathless, the echoes of Meera's voice—her proposal, her absence, her tears—swirling in his head.

He sits on the edge of the bed at dawn, lost, terrified that his delay could cost him everything.

CUT TO:

The empty side of the bed.

The unopened messages on his phone.

The night still heavy around him.

END PAGE 10

BLACKOUT.

PG - 11

PAGE 11

INT. ARJUN B'S APARTMENT – BEDROOM – NIGHT (NIGHT 5)

Arjun B lies in bed, the sheets tangled around him. Meera's side is cold, empty—she's been gone for three days now.

He closes his eyes, dreading what's coming but unable to resist sleep's pull.

NIGHTMARE SEQUENCE – THE FULL REALIZATION

The dream begins as before—but this time, it's different. Sharper. More visceral.

REVERSE SEQUENCE – ARJUN A'S JOURNEY (BACKWARDS IN TIME)

We move *backwards* through Reality A, like rewinding a tape:

- PRESENT: Arjun A at the tapri, staring at the cafe he never enters.
- REWIND: Years blur past—seasons change, same routine, same emptiness.
- REWIND: Arjun A at the gym, lifting heavier, hurting more.
- REWIND: Office promotions, hollow congratulations from Sameer.
- REWIND: Empty apartment, meal prep for one, the rituals of loneliness.

Then—THE MOMENT IT BROKE:

INT. THE LOST CAFE – 5 YEARS AGO (REALITY A – THE BREAKUP)

Young Arjun A and Meera sit at their table. The atmosphere is tense, strained.

MEERA (A)
(voice breaking)

I can't keep waiting, Arjun. Five months we've been together, and you still can't tell me where this is going.

YOUNG ARJUN A

(defensive, scared)

I just need more time. Career is unstable right now—

MEERA (A)

It's always something. Time, career, timing. When is it ever the right moment?

YOUNG ARJUN A

(unable to articulate his fear)

I... I don't know if I can give you what you need.

The words land like a bomb. Meera's eyes fill with tears.

MEERA (A)

Then I guess we're done.

She stands, walks away. Young Arjun A sits frozen, unable to move, unable to call her back.

The cafe's golden light dims to grey.

ARJUN B (V.O., WATCHING THIS)

(horrified whisper)

No... no, that's not—that's not how it—

But he **feels** it. The regret. The paralysis. The fear that masqueraded as caution.

THE NIGHTMARE DEEPENS

The scene SHATTERS. Arjun B is now **inside** Arjun A's skin, living the aftermath:

MONTAGE — LIVING THE LOSS:

- Waking up alone, every morning, for 1,825 days.
- Checking phone for messages that never come.
- Seeing couples at the cafe through the window, feeling the ache.
- The gym becoming not fitness but punishment.
- Sameer's proud words: "You moved on so well"—but the hollow echo inside.
- The tapri ritual: "Kuch jagah bas dekhne ke liye hoti hain, Chacha."

Arjun B *experiences* all of this as REAL. Not metaphor. Not symbol. REAL.

INT. NIGHTMARE SPACE – VOID

Arjun B stands in darkness. Before him, Arjun A—his mirror, his ghost, his warning.

ARJUN A

(hollow, tired)

This isn't a dream, is it?

ARJUN B

(terrified)

It can't be real. It's just... it's just my fear—

ARJUN A

(shakes head)

You feel it. The weight of five years. The texture of regret. The specific ache of her absence on a Tuesday morning. Dreams don't have that kind of detail.

Arjun B's breathing quickens.

ARJUN B

Then what is this?

ARJUN A

(quiet, devastating)

A warning. Or a memory. Or both.

The darkness around them begins to pulse—reality bleeding, glitching.

ARJUN A (CONT'D)

You're living my life at night. I'm living yours. And the space between is closing.

ARJUN B

(desperate)

How do I stop it?

ARJUN A

(looks at him with infinite sadness)

You answer her. The way I never could.

INT. ARJUN B'S APARTMENT – BEDROOM – NIGHT

Arjun B JOLTS AWAKE, gasping, drenched in sweat.

He sits up violently, hands shaking, looking around the empty bedroom.

The silence is deafening.

He reaches for his phone—no messages from Meera. She's still away.
Still giving him space.

And in this moment, her absence feels **exactly** like the nightmare.

ARJUN B

(whispered, terrified)

Oh god... it's real. It's all real.

The realization crashes over him: These aren't just dreams. This is a **life**. A life that exists. A life that could **become** his if he doesn't choose differently.

He looks at the empty side of the bed.

The nightmare isn't the dream.

The nightmare is waking up to this emptiness.

And right now—with Meera away, the apartment silent, the bed half-empty—he's living it.

ARJUN B (CONT'D)

(broken whisper)

I can't... I can't lose her.

He grabs his phone, fingers hovering over Meera's contact.

Types: "I need to talk to you. Please."

Stares at it. Deletes it.

Types again: "I love you. I'm sorry."

Deletes it.

Types: "Come home."

His finger hovers over send.

He can't press it. The paralysis from the nightmare still grips him.

He drops the phone, buries his face in his hands.

The curse has him trapped—living both lives, unable to choose, the delay itself becoming the decision.

FADE TO BLACK.

END PAGE 11

CUT TO:

